

AMÉLIE POULAIN, YANN TIERSEN & THE IMAGINARY PARIS

The Postcard That Became a Pilgrimage



In the year 2000 the accordion is the sound of your grandparents' Sunday, of bad films about Paris, of tourists at the foot of the Eiffel Tower.



One year later, students in Tokyo, Berlin and Brooklyn are learning the accordion and the toy piano.

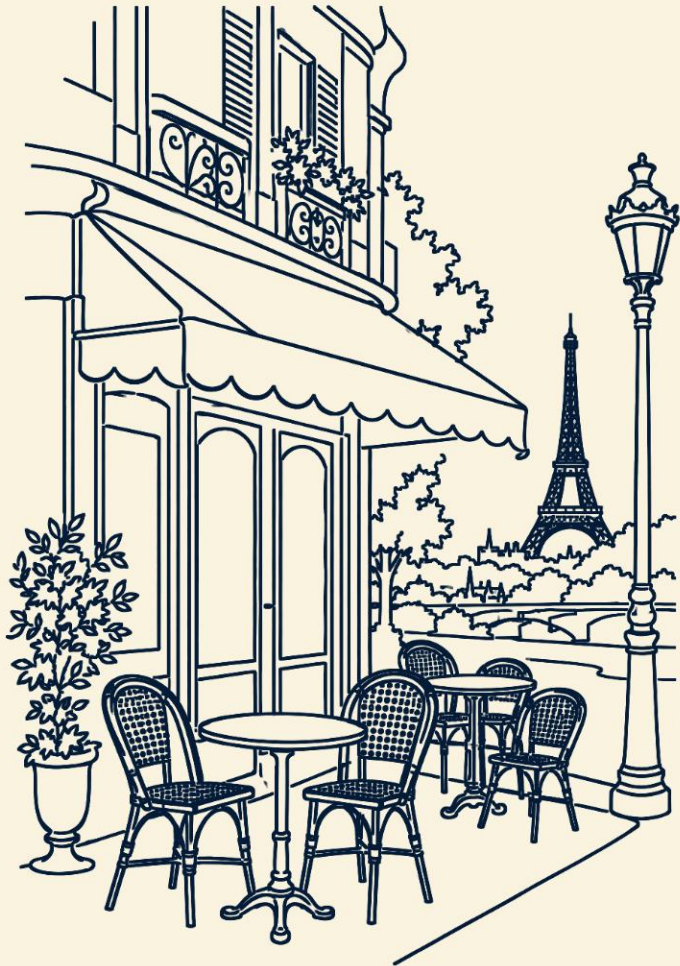
The Instrument That Was Dead

A film gave an instrument back its dignity

And gave a city a face it did not quite have — but that everyone now expects to find.

Tonight: how a fairy tale about a shy waitress rewrote the world's idea of Paris.

A Journey Through a Dreamed Paris



Introduction to the Subject and Guiding Thread

The film.

Le Fabuleux Destin d'Amélie Poulain, Jean-Pierre Jeunet, April 2001.

The music.

Yann Tiersen, a Breton composer of melancholy instrumentals, whose records Jeunet discovered by accident in a car.

The thread.

Together they built a Paris with no graffiti, no traffic, no present tense — and the audience chose to believe it.

The Paris of Amélie never existed. Which is exactly why millions came looking for it.

PART 1

THE FAIRY-TALE MONTMARTRE

*A Director's Notebook, a Casting Gamble, and a
Café on Rue Lepic*



The Four Founding Dates

The arc of a phenomenon in four milestones.

1996

Yann Tiersen releases Rue des Cascades. The sound exists before the film.

2001

25 April: Amélie opens in France. Eight and a half million tickets.

2002

Five Oscar nominations, four Césars. The most successful French film in America.

2017

Amélie opens on Broadway as a musical. The dream keeps returning.

From a Breton bedroom studio to a Broadway stage: the journey of a mood.

Jeunet's Notebook

Twenty Years of Small Pleasures

The method.

For years Jean-Pierre Jeunet collected tiny observations in notebooks: cracking the crust of a crème brûlée, skimming stones on a canal, plunging a hand into a sack of grain.



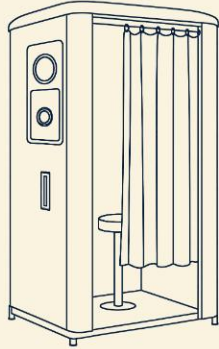
The pedigree.

Delicatessen (1991), The City of Lost Children (1995), then a bruising Hollywood experience on Alien: Resurrection (1997).

The film is made of the smallest possible units of happiness, assembled with obsessive precision.

The Gamble of the Casting

Written for Someone Else



Emily Watson

The English actress the film was written for. Her French was uncertain; her schedule was full; she withdrew.



Audrey Tautou

A poster in the street for Vénus Beauté (Institut). Within minutes of her audition, the character had a face.

The whole dreamed Paris rests on one face that the camera could not stop looking at.



The Café des Deux Moulins

Rue Lepic, Montmartre — the Set That Was Already There

Real places. The café at 15 rue Lepic; the grocer Collignon on rue des Trois Frères; the Lamarck–Caulaincourt Métro; the Sacré-Cœur; the Canal Saint-Martin; a photo booth at the Gare de l'Est.

Cleaned by computer. Graffiti erased, cars removed, posters replaced, the sky repainted.

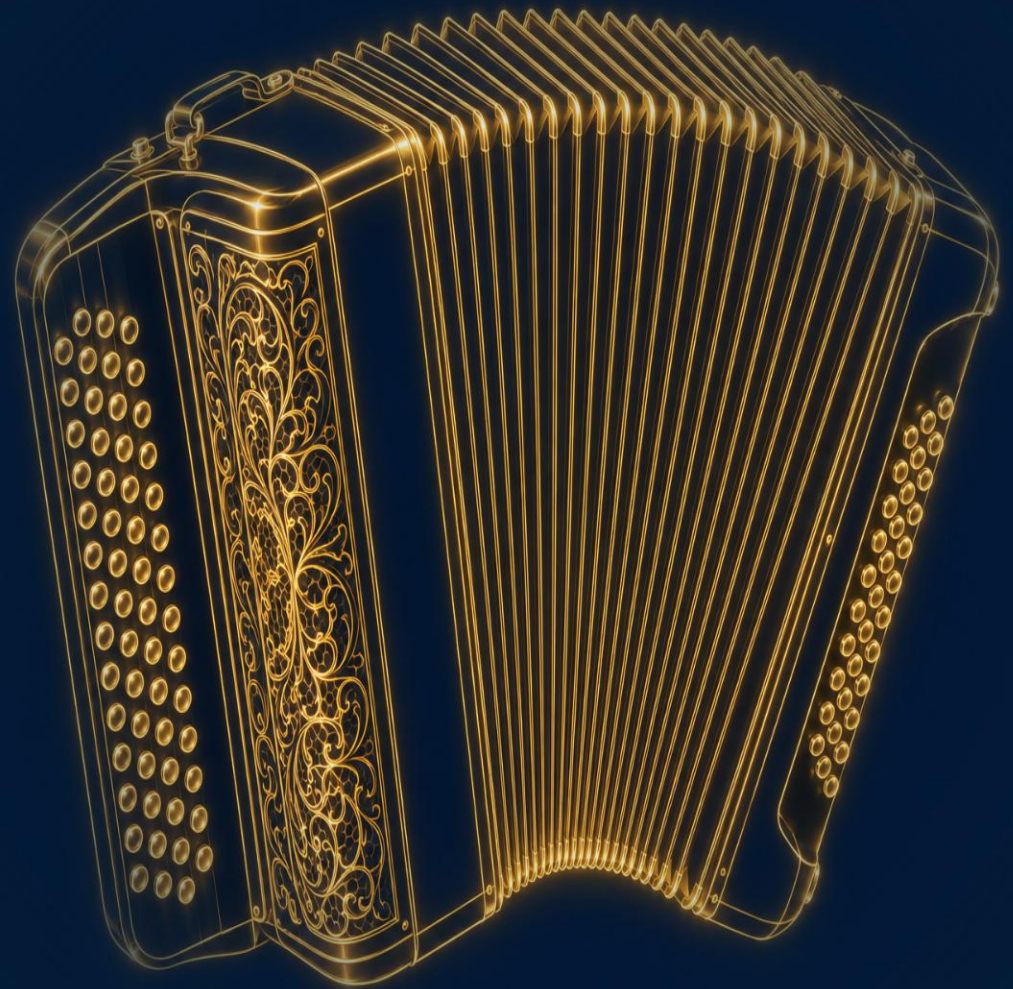
The result. Every location is real and none of them look like themselves. The audience cannot tell where the city ends and the dream begins.

The café still stands. It now serves a crème brûlée named after the film to visitors from every continent.

PART 2

THE SOUND OF A DREAMED PARIS

*Yann Tiersen, a Toy Piano, and the Return of the
Accordion*





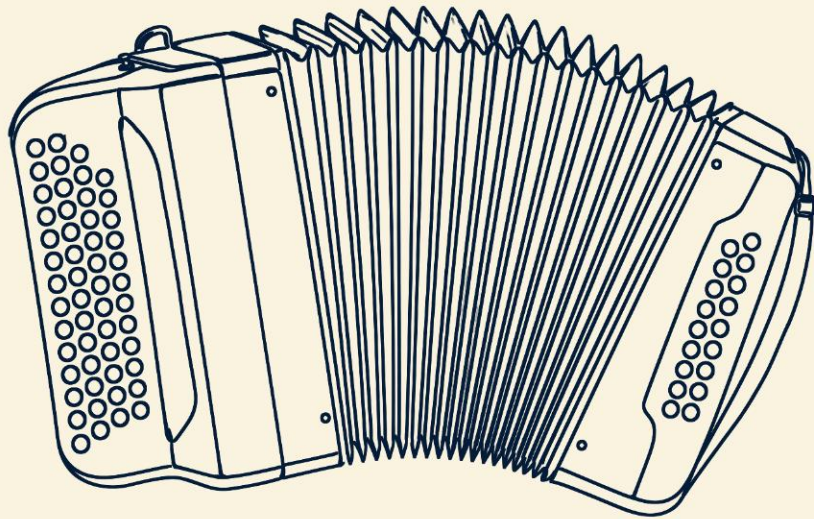
A CD in a Car

How Jeunet Found Yann Tiersen

Brest, 1970. Yann Tiersen trains as a classical violinist and pianist, breaks his violin in a rock phase, and begins recording alone in his flat with whatever instruments he can find. **The accident.** A production assistant plays a Tiersen record in the car on the way to a location scout. **The score.** Mostly existing pieces from *Rue des Cascades* (1996), *Le Phare* (1998) and *L'Absente* (2001), plus new ones written in a few weeks — including *La Valse d'Amélie* and *Comptine d'un autre été*.

The music was not written for the film. The film was cut to the music.

The Accordion Restored



An Instrument Comes Back from Exile

Before.

In France the accordion is *bal musette*, the 1930s, something between folklore and embarrassment.

After.

Tiersen plays it like a minimalist — repeated figures, a child's harmonium, a toy piano, a melodica, bicycle wheels.

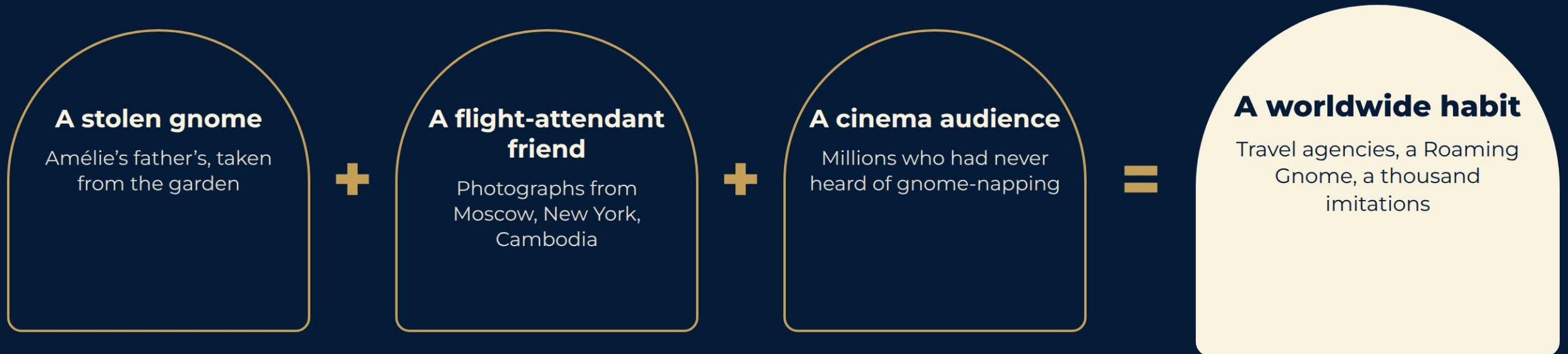
The Césars.

Best Music, 2002. Tiersen, uneasy with the fame, spends the next decades moving as far from *Amélie* as possible — to Ushant, to electronics, to Breton.

He gave the accordion back its respectability — and spent twenty years trying to escape the gift.

The Travelling Gnome

A Joke That Became a Global Habit



Amélie exported not just a Paris, but a way of playing with the world.

The Numbers

France

Eight and a half million tickets in 2001 — the year's top French film. Thirteen César nominations.

8.5 M

America

More than thirty-three million dollars at the US box office — the highest ever for a French film.

The Academy

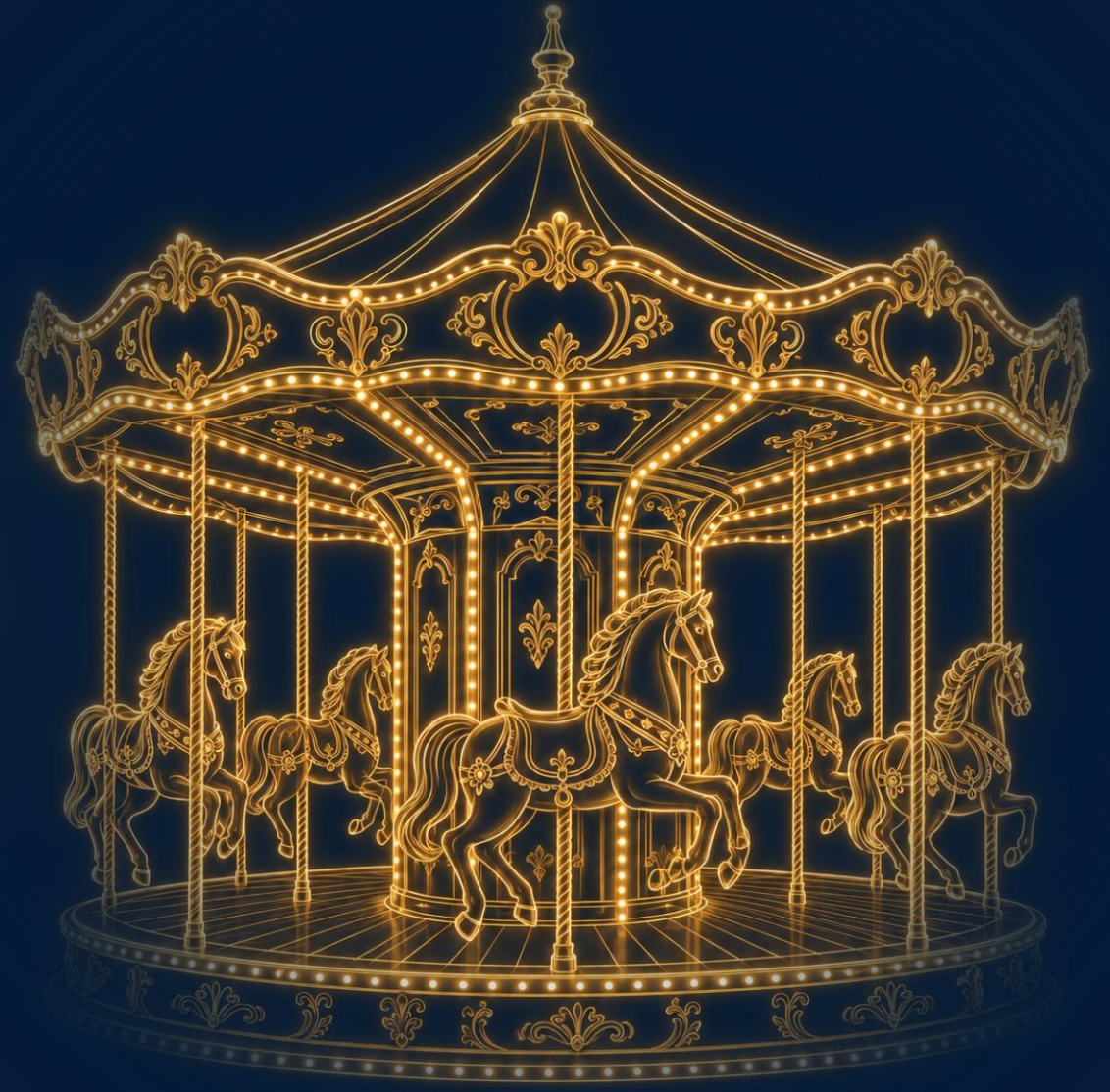
Five Oscar nominations in 2002. It won none; it did not need to.

Cannes had turned the film down. The world did not.

PART 3

THE ETERNAL RETURN

*The Postcard, the Critique, and the Paris the
Audience Still Hopes to Visit*





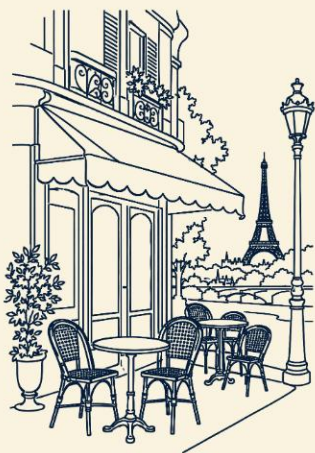
The Critique: Whose Paris?

The charge. In *Libération*, the critic Serge Kaganski accused the film of a sanitised, nostalgic Paris — a Montmartre scrubbed of immigrants, of 2001, of reality — and called the vision reactionary.

The defence. Jeunet answered that it was a fairy tale, not a documentary; that nostalgia is a legitimate colour; that every great Paris film invented its own city.

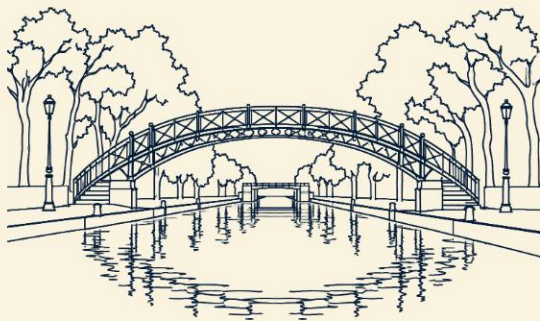
Why it matters. The debate is the subject: a country arguing about which Paris it wants the world to see — and the world choosing the postcard.

The dream was never innocent. It was a choice — and an extraordinarily successful one.



Montmartre

The Deux Moulins, the Collignon grocery and the Sacré-Cœur steps become stations of a pilgrimage.



The Canal Saint-Martin

A working-class canal becomes the most photographed place to skim a stone in Europe — and the heart of a new, gentrified east Paris.



The Imaginary City

Midnight in Paris, Emily in Paris, Ratatouille: twenty years of films and series shoot the Paris Amélie taught the world to expect.

The audience does not want the real Paris. It wants the one it has already seen.

Twenty-Five Years On

A Musical, a Re-Release, and a Dream That Will Not Fade

Broadway, 2017.

Amélie, A New Musical, with Phillipa Soo. A modest run — but proof that the story travels without Montmartre, without Tautou, without Tiersen.

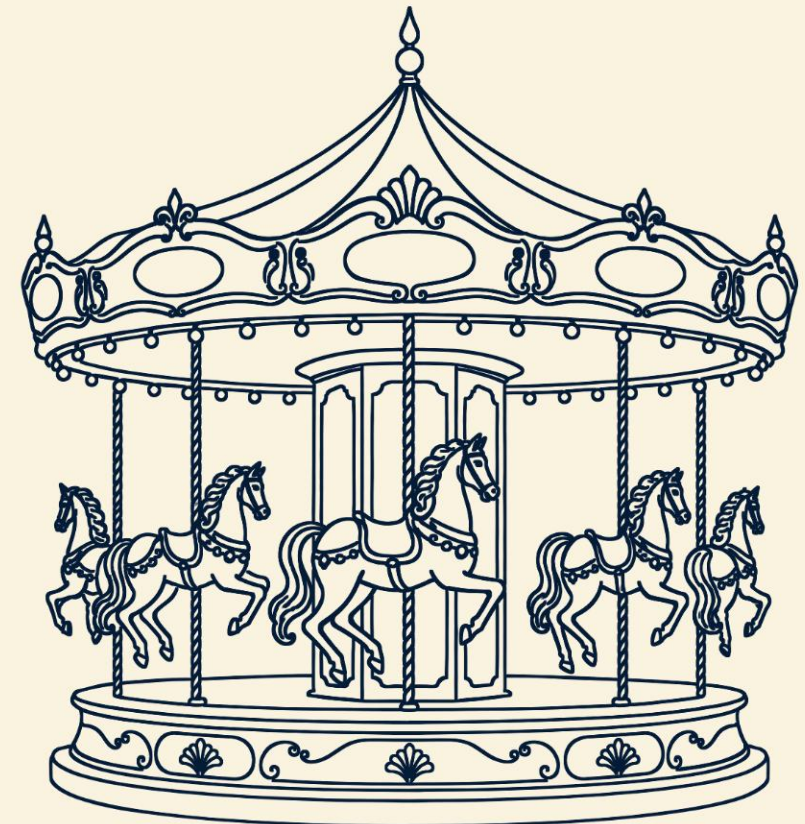
The re-releases.

Restored editions return to cinemas for the twentieth anniversary; the soundtrack remains among the best-selling film scores of the century.

The question for tonight.

When you picture Paris — the café, the accordion, the green light, the girl with the bob — ask where the picture came from.

The dreamed Paris outlived its decade. It is now the default.



A Dreamed Paris in One Hour

A director's notebook of small pleasures became the most successful French film ever shown in America.

A Breton musician recording alone in his flat gave the accordion and the toy piano back to a generation.

A real neighbourhood was digitally scrubbed into a fairy tale — and then remade itself in the fairy tale's image.

And a nation argued about which Paris it wanted to show, while the world bought tickets to the postcard.



Amélie did not film Paris. It filmed the Paris you were hoping for — and made it the one you will look for.

Sources & Further Reading



Reading

Serge Kaganski, "Amélie pas jolie", Libération, 31 May 2001 · Jean-Pierre Jeunet, Une vie de cinéma · Isabelle Vanderschelden, Amélie (Cine-Files French Film Guides) · Phil Powrie (ed.), The Cinema of France.



Listening, in Order

Yann Tiersen: Rue des Cascades (1996) · Le Phare (1998) · L'Absente (2001) · Le Fabuleux Destin d'Amélie Poulain, original soundtrack (2001).



Watching

Le Fabuleux Destin d'Amélie Poulain (2001) · Delicatessen (1991) · The City of Lost Children (1995) · Vénus Beauté (Institut), Tonie Marshall (1999).